

TABLE OF SCRIPTURAL PRINCIPLES--HOW REGARDED BY THE CHURCHES.

SCRIPTURAL PRINCIPLES.	GOVERNMENT CENTRALIZED.		GOVERNMENT LOCALIZED.	GOVERNMENT HARMONIZED.
	<i>The Papacy.</i>	<i>Prelacy.</i>	<i>Independency.</i>	<i>Presbytery.</i>
1. The only King and Head of the Church is the Lord Jesus Christ.	Repudiated by substitution of the Pope.	Repudiated. In England the civil monarch substituted.	Accepted.	Accepted.
2. The visible Church is the organized society of those professing belief in and bearing testimony unto Christ.	Repudiated by rejection of all not subject to the Pope.	Repudiated by High Church. All rejected not subject to prelates.	Accepted.	Accepted.
3. The Scriptures are the only ultimate standard of law to the Church.	Repudiated by adding to and subverting its teachings.	Accepted, but power retained to decree rites and ceremonies.	Accepted.	Accepted.
4. Apostolic scriptural practice is of universal and perpetual obligation.	Repudiated, preferring patristic practices.	Professedly accepted, but patristic preferred.	Accepted.	Accepted.
5. The office of elder is essential and permanent in the visible Church.	Practically repudiated.	Practically repudiated.	Teaching elder allowed.	Accepted.
6. The office of the ministry is divinely authoritative and permanent.	Repudiated by changing to sacrificing priests.	Accepted but in name changed to priests.	Almost fully accepted.	Accepted.
7. The office of elder or bishop is identical.	Repudiated.	Repudiated.	Accepted.	Accepted.
8. Every congregation should have a plurality of elders, among whom the duties of teaching and ruling are distributed.	Repudiated.	Repudiated.	Partially accepted. Ruling elder disallowed.	Accepted.
9. The highest position is that of elder or bishop, whose rule is wholly ministerial.	Repudiated.	Repudiated.	Accepted.	Accepted.
10. Every church should have a plurality of deacons conjoined with the elders, specially instructed with temporal affairs.	Repudiated. Changed to inferior ministers.	Repudiated. Changed to inferior ministers.	Partially accepted. Deacons elevated to the eldership.	Accepted. Not carried out by some branches.
11. The election of all officers is an inherent right of the members of the Church.	Repudiated in practice.	Repudiated.	Accepted.	Accepted. Not carried out by some.
12. Admission to office must be by prayer, and the imposition of the hands of the body of elders.	Repudiated: prelatic only valid.	Repudiated: prelatic only valid.	Repudiated, or only partially accepted.	Accepted fully as to ministers.
13. The course of administration in every congregation is by representative associated elders.	Repudiated.	Repudiated.	Repudiated. People substituted.	Accepted.
14. The congregations of a locality form one church, which is governed by their associated elders.	Repudiated as to government.	Repudiated as to government.	Repudiated.	Accepted.
15. Administration in difficult cases of doctrine, discipline, worship, and government, is authoritatively effected by assemblies of representative elders.	Repudiated, giving power to prelates and the Pope.	Repudiated, giving power to prelates.	Repudiated.	Accepted, and nationally exercised.
Summation, . . .	7. Repudiated. 8. Perverted.	7. Repudiated. 8. Perverted.	5. Repudiated. 3. Changed. 7. Accepted.	All Accepted.

**Westminster Confession
Presbyterian (1647)**

XXXI Of Synods & Councils.

I. FOR THE BETTER GOVERNMENT, and further edification of the Church, there ought to be such assemblies as are commonly called Synods or Councils.

II. As magistrates may lawfully call a synod of ministers, and other fit persons, to consult and advise with about matters of religion ; so if magistrates be open enemies to the church, the ministers of Christ, of themselves, by virtue of their office, or they, with other fit persons upon delegation from their churches, may meet together in such assemblies.

III. It belongeth to synods and councils ministerially to determine controversies of faith, and cases of conscience ; to set down rules and directions for the better ordering of the public worship of God, and government of His Church ; to receive complaints in cases of mal-administration, and authoritatively to determine the same ; which **decrees** and determinations, if consonant to the Word of God, are to be received with reverence and submission, not only for their agreement with the Word, but also for the power whereby they are made, as being an ordinance of God, appointed thereunto in His Word.

IV. All synods and councils since the apostles' times, whether general or particular, may err, and many have erred : therefore they are not to be made the rule of faith or practice, but to be used as a help in both.

V. Synods and councils are to handle or conclude nothing but that which is ecclesiastical ; and are not to intermeddle with civil affairs, which concern the commonwealth, unless by way of humble petition, in cases extraordinary ; or by way of advice for satisfaction of conscience, if they be thereunto required by the civil magistrate.

**v Savoy Declaration
Independent (1658)
Institution of Churches.**

VI. Besides these particular Churches, there is not instituted by Christ any Church more extensive or Catholic intrusted with power for the administration of His Ordinances or the execution of any authority in His Name.

XXV. As all Churches and all the members of them are bound to pray continually for the good or prosperity of all the Churches of Christ in all places, and upon all occasions to further itso the churches themselvesought to hold communion amongst themselves for their peace, increase of love, and mutual edification.

XXVI. In cases of Difficulties or Differences, either in point of Doctrine or in Administrations, wherein either the Churches in general are concerned, or any one Church, in their Peace, Union, and Edification, or any Member or Members of any Church are injured in or by any proceeding in Censures not agreeable to Truth and Order, it is according to the mind of Christ that many Churches holding communion together do by their Messengers meet in a Synod or Council to consider and give their **advice** in or about that matter in difference, to be reported to all the Churches concerned : Howbeit, these synods so assembled are **not intrusted with any Church Power** properly so called, or with any Jurisdiction over the Churches themselves, to exercise any **Censures**, either over any churches or Persons, or to impose their determinations on the Churches or Officers.

XXVII. Besides these occasioned Synods or Councils, there are not instituted by Christ any stated Synods in a fixed Combination of Churches or their Officers in lesser or greater Assemblies, nor are there any Synods appointed by Christ in a way of Subordination to one another.

Westminster versus Savoy

Editor

A perusal of the twin columns on the page opposite will yield a direct contrast, highlighted at apposite critical points by the words in heavy type. One sees Westminster's **decree**, which corresponds to the Greek δογμαί of the Textus Receptus in Acts 16 : 4, juxtaposed with **advice** given in the Savoy article XXVI, which latter corresponds with nothing anywhere in the Textus Receptus with respect to the matters of Synodical Church Government.

Notwithstanding the fact that we have yet to print the full details of Porteus' massed phalanx of evidence drawn from the New Testament with regard to the existence of several congregations being under the rule of one group of elders, enough has already come to the fore to indicate the **Scriptural solidity** of the Presbyterian system (and of course, of the Continental Reformed System.). One might ask the following pertinent questions :

(i) Does Scripture teach us of "Synods" or "Assemblies" ?

Yes. Scripture says yes, Westminster says yes, and *even Savoy admits it, though in some watered down fashion.*

(ii) Does this Scriptural Synod issue **decrees** or **advice** ?

Scripture says **decree**, Westminster says **decree**, Savoy says *advice.*

(iii) Which Confessional standard is therefore **Scriptural** ?

(The reader can answer this for himself).

But there are further matters of note in this comparison. Article XXV of the Savoy Declaration makes a fatal admission. It speaks of "all Churches and all the members of them are *bound to pray continually for the good or prosperity of all the Churches of Christ in all places, and upon all occasions to further it*", and that they "ought to hold communion amongst themselves for their peace, increase of love, and mutual edification". Now all such admonitions are well encompassed within the Presbyterian system, but under Presbyterianism all such inter-church fraternisation is under the controlling discipline of the Synodical codes of practice and the Doctrinal Standards. Under the Savoy teaching, such inter-church relationships are left under the vague but sugary recommendations of Article XXV with no controls on procedure, protocol, legalities, co-ordination, finance, and above all, Doctrinal Orthodoxy. Under the Savoy rules one could find (and in English Dissent, *did find*), orthodox churches fraternizing with heterodox, and consequent intermingling of believers and pseudo-believers under the aegis of one congregation. And how is one to pray intelligently for other churches, if the churches do not, as a body, organize synodically and circulate information concerning various churches

¹ See footnote 16 on page 10 of this Journal.

and their needs ? How can there be intelligent missionary activity, or training of office bearers, printing of Bibles, or practical operations of material relief for Churches where natural catastrophes, or war, or persecution wreak havoc in the lives of God's dear people ? Under the Savoy system, all this is left very much on an ad hoc basis, even though article XXV exhorts that these things be done. But under the Westminster system, deliberate, intelligent, and co-ordinated operations in all these spheres can be promoted and maintained, and backed with the decrees issued at Synodical level.

But Savoy's Article XXV is a give-away ! It takes a huge step in the Presbyterian direction, as if tacitly admitting that, well, yes, these Presbyterians *have* got something, after all ! Churches must be concerned about each other ! But then it leaves the whole thing up in limbo without a scrap of rights or powers of enforcement, or any controlling disciplinary procedures ! A toothless tiger, indeed !

But Savoy article XXVI is an even bigger give-away ! Herein is the full admission : Yes, well you know, one just has to have Synods ! It *is* there in the Scriptures after all ! And, you know, they *can* be useful, if only on an occasional basis, without any **decretive powers** ! Just to give **advice**, and not to be **intrusted with any Church Power...** ! And all those, of course, who are not of a mind to take such a Synod's "advice", need not bother to take it. Nobody can make them. What a synod ! What a system !

Savoy Article XXVII is a thorough recipe for chaos. Synods, it says, yes, but only occasionally, nothing must be fixed, and no authority ascribed thereto. No regular Synodical meeting every quarter, or yearly, or whatever. Only as occasioned ! Nor any fixed "combination of churches or their officers in lesser or greater assemblies", nor any differential levels of subordination. Herewith, reader, behold the formula for organised ad - hoc -ery ! Official ! Thou shalt be ad hoc and disorganised ! And this *is a decree*, the only one you'll get out of a Savoy Synod ! We decree that we shall not issue any decrees !

One can imagine under this farrago of half - truth, some poor Church member, suffering some grave injustice from his minister and elders, trying to get the ministers and elders of his whole, or just part, of his denomination together, to get the matter resolved ! Will they all meet, at great expense, and inconvenience, to sort out this one poor fellow ? More likely they will just fob him off, human nature being what it is, especially when no doubt his miscreant minister and elders will be denying the whole thing to their colleagues in other churches. Or at best, they might make a note of his complaint, and store it until enough other material accumulates to warrant calling a Synod ! Poor chap will wait years, and all he'll get at the end of it all, is **advice** ! His minister and elders will be able to just carry on and blithely ignore Synod if they wish !

Under the Westminster system of fixed Synods and Presbyteries, with fixed boundaries of authority, fixed frequencies of convocation, decretive power, and

the back-up of Ecclesiastical Sanctions to *enforce* the Synod's deliberations on the matter, the miscreants would thereby be unable to elude justice any longer, or indeed, to impede the plaintiff's complaints from reaching Synodical level in the first place.

Likewise, the plaintiff, and the defendants, would have the benefit of independent, detached, wise, highly qualified, and experienced Synodical Officers as judges in the affair. Local prejudices would be thereby obviated.

Under the Savoy system, which in effect, is **the** commonly accepted principle of today, the poor plaintiff will find out something of what St. Paul meant, when he wrote in II Timothy 3 : 5 ;

"Having a form of godliness....."

but

"denying the power thereof :"

Sure, a Savoy style of Synod is just that. An overall lip-service is made in concession to the Scriptural form, but then this form is evacuated of all power. The Presbyterian and Reformed Synodical system alone grants form **and** power to these Scripture-mandated Councils, and alone can take proper Scriptural steps to ensure that the relationships between individual churches are to be maintained under the same discipline as relationships entailed within a congregation, in the true spirit of the Apostle, when he said :

"Let all things be done decently and in order"

I Cor. 14 : 40.

CONCLUSIONS :

The reader will note that the above material is provocative and is a direct polemic against the style of churches that most evangelical people in England are familiar with in these modern times. Free Evangelicals, Reformed Baptists, Pentecostals, Plymouth Brethren (open), and certain various 'house-church' movements all practice, in effect, the provisions of the Independent creed, the original Savoy declaration made in 1658, in Puritan England, and made under the guiding hands of certain eminent Puritans of those days, men of unimpeachable standing in the Reformed Faith, prominent amongst whom were no less than John Owen and Thomas Goodwin. It may well be asked, "how dare we criticise such great and godly men ?" But four vital considerations arise in this respect. **First**, the Holy Scriptures are paramount over all else, no matter what great reputations are at stake. **Secondly**, the framers of the Savoy Declaration went a long way in *admitting* the Scripturalness of Synods. **Thirdly**, the Puritanism of the Cromwellian period was suffering a reaction against "over-bearing" and "dictatorial" attitudes (plus downright pernicketyness, heterodoxy, and effective treason) that was manifest amongst English Presbyterians, and **Fourthly**, the two principals in all this, Owen and Goodwin, expressed certain pro-Presbyterian inclinations which we examine, as far as space will allow, on the following pages.